# Three Places Families Get Stuck When Preparing Ahead for a Medicaid Application

What each one looks like, why it happens, and a small habit for each.

Most families who try to get ahead of a Medicaid application get stuck in the same three places. None of them is a failing. Each is what happens when a big, vague job has no first step, and each has a small habit that helps.

## 1 Not knowing what documents Medicaid would ask for

**WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE** You sit down to get Dad's paperwork in order and stop at the first question: which paperwork? So the folder stays empty, or it fills with everything, appliance manuals included.

**WHY IT HAPPENS** Nobody hands a family the list, and there isn't one list. USA.gov says what a state Medicaid agency requires depends on the state, though it does name kinds of things an agency may ask for: a name and date of birth, a Social Security number, proof of citizenship or immigration status, proof of income, and information about current insurance. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** List what exists and where it is, by kind: identity, income, bank accounts, investments, retirement accounts, insurance, property. The National Institute on Aging suggests keeping important papers in one place and telling someone trusted where to find them. Which of those records Dad's state would want is a question to write down for your Medicaid planner. [2]

## 2 Feeling buried by forms, deadlines and requests before there are any

**WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE** You've heard the stories: the long form, the dates to answer by, the letters asking for more. Nothing has been filed and nobody is asking Dad for anything, and it already feels like too much.

**WHY IT HAPPENS** The whole process gets pictured at once. In general terms it has two parts, the federal Administration for Community Living says: an application form, and documentation to verify general and financial requirements. The part a family can work on ahead of time is the documents. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Take one category at a time: statements this month, insurance the next. Keep a running page of your questions about the form, the dates and the letters, and bring it to your Medicaid planner, who explains the general application process. When an application is eventually prepared, it is prepared with an applications specialist. Nobody needs you to know the form today.

## 3 Worrying that one missing paper could hold everything up

**WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE** You can't find the deed, or the last statement from an account Dad closed, and the gap starts to feel bigger than everything you did find.

**WHY IT HAPPENS** The worry has something behind it. The Administration for Community Living says it may take longer for a state to determine eligibility when required documents aren't provided on time. But that describes an application under way. Nobody is applying, and a gap found in a quiet year is one there is time to ask about. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write the gap down: what's missing, where you've looked, who might know. A list of what you haven't located is part of the file, not a mark against it. Whether the record would be needed, and how to get a copy, are questions for your Medicaid planner or for the bank, insurer or office that issued it.

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**The one habit behind all three**

Write down what exists, where it is and the date. Leave what it means, and what Dad's state requires, to the people whose job that is.

**What this guide doesn't do**

It doesn't say which records Dad's state requires, what a missing one would mean, or whether or when to apply. It names three sticking points, the same three the Medicaid Planning Roadmap sees at this step. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

### Ready for the next step?

You know the three places families get stuck and the small habit for each. The planning interview picks up from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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**WHERE THIS COMES FROM**

The kinds of things a state agency may ask for come from USA.gov, the description of applying from the federal Administration for Community Living, and the advice to keep papers in one place from the National Institute on Aging. The three sticking points are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.


1. USA.gov, How to apply for Medicaid and CHIP
2. National Institute on Aging, Getting Your Affairs in Order Checklist: Documents to Prepare for the Future
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid


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